Dear Members of the MRes and PhD Commission,

I am writing to formally request a change of supervisor and research group. I am currently supervised by Dr. Joren Gijsbrechts in the Business Network Dynamics (BuNeD) research group, and I would like to transfer to the Group for Research in Economics and Finance (GREF), under the supervision of Dr. Emanuele Rizzo.

During my MRes and the first year of my PhD, I explored several topics in operations research using empirical, optimization, and game-theoretic methods. Through this work, I came to recognize that my research interests sit more naturally in empirical corporate finance, specifically on capital markets and the firm's information environment. I attended Dr. Rizzo's empirical corporate finance course this semester, which confirmed that both the research questions and the methodology of this field fit my background in economics and my longer-term research agenda.

Since March 2026, I have been working with Dr. Rizzo on what will become the first chapter of my dissertation, with the working title "Website Access Rules and Visibility in AI-Powered Search." The project examines whether firms whose websites block AI search crawlers (such as ChatGPT Search, Perplexity, and Claude) are systematically less visible to investors who rely on these tools, and whether reduced visibility translates into measurable changes in the firm's information environment, such as analyst forecast dispersion and bid-ask spreads. The main contribution is a new firm-level measure of AI search visibility, constructed from the technical configuration of corporate websites rather than from disclosure content. This measure captures a form of information friction that does not appear in standard disclosure data and that firms may inherit unintentionally from default website templates. The project speaks to research on the technology of investor information acquisition and to emerging work on how AI systems interact with web content.

To support this study, I am constructing an original firm-level dataset that covers approximately 9,500 US public firms identified from Compustat. The dataset records the crawling permissions of 4,350 unique corporate websites across 62 documented AI crawlers, distinguishing search, training, and user-triggered bots. I am currently extending the cross-section into a monthly panel from 2021 to 2025 using the Wayback Machine, which will allow me to identify firms that changed their AI access policy over time and use these changes for causal identification. Data construction is expected to be complete in the coming weeks.

My timeline for the Research Proposal is as follows:

- Late April – early May: Mechanism test using AI search APIs to verify that blocked firms are cited less often in AI-generated answers.
- May 4 – May 17: Regression analysis linking web-access restrictions to information environment outcomes.

• May 18 – May 24: Drafting the first chapter, and working with Dr. Rizzo to develop preliminary directions for the remaining two chapters of the dissertation.

• End of May: Submit the full draft of the first chapter to Dr. Rizzo for review.

• Early June: Present the Research Proposal draft to the GREF research group and inform the PhD Office of the presentation date.

• June 19: Submit the final Research Proposal and other documents to the PhD Programme Office.

I remain grateful to Dr. Gijsbrechts for his guidance during my time in BuNeD, and I thank him for his continued support through this transition. I would also like to thank the Commission for considering my request.

Sincerely,

Xueyang Liu

April 20, 2026